



A FIELD GUIDE

The Game of Life

Stop playing everyone else's.
Start playing your own.

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”The two most important days of your life are the day you are born and the day you find out why.”

— often attributed to Mark Twain

The Game of Life · First edition

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DEDICATION

For anyone who ever felt like they
were playing a game they didn't
choose.

You can put it down. You can play
your own.

CONTENTS

The map.

Three parts. Read in order the first time — they build on each other.

Part I — The Game

- 1 · Life is a game
- 2 · The lie you were sold
- 3 · You are an architect of reality
- 4 · We all start somewhere

Part II — Know Yourself

- 5 · Maslow & the climb
- 6 · Purpose is born from pain
- 7 · Ikigai: your reason for being
- 8 · Integrity: the inner foundation
- 9 · The man in the glass
- 10 · Self-actualization & magnetism

Part III — Live It

- 11 · Inputs decide outputs
- 12 · Money is a byproduct
- 13 · Travel: the fastest way to grow

- 14 · Love: the richest level
- 15 · Fulfillment over dopamine
- 16 · Killing the shoulds
- 17 · From vision to reality
- 18 · Enjoy the game
- 19 · A life well lived

HOW TO USE THIS

**Read once. Then
work it.**

This is a short book on purpose. It's built to be read in an afternoon — and then used for years.

The first time through, just read. Let the ideas land in order; each chapter builds on the one before it, and the whole thing only clicks when you see how the pieces connect.

Then come back with a pen. Scattered through the book are **exercises** — short, honest prompts with space to write. They are where the real work happens. Reading about purpose changes nothing; answering the questions does. Don't rush them, and don't lie to yourself in them — the only person you'd be fooling is the one holding the pen.

Keep what resonates. Argue with what doesn't. This is my map of the game — take it, then draw your own.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

A note from me.

I didn't find my purpose in a classroom. I dropped out of school two years early — top of my class — to go see the world.

My mom was a flight attendant, so flights were nearly free. I just had to figure out where I'd sleep once I landed. That turned into years of backpacking, couch-surfing, stretches basically homeless, flipping anything I could to make money. Eighty countries. No degree. No formal job. Ever.

From the outside it looked like drifting. It wasn't. It was the most important education of my life — because every single day I had to answer one question with my actions: *what is actually worth doing?*

Years later that same question built a company. I converted a van during COVID, filmed it, and it went viral. That accident became Mothership — fifteen vans and a million-dollar business. Then more companies. Then investing in founders building the future. Then a life in Bali I genuinely designed on purpose.

None of it came from a five-year plan. It came from getting clear on what I was actually here to do — and trusting that if I served that honestly, the rest would follow. It did. The money came later, and it was never the point: it was a *byproduct* of doing real work, and a tool to go deeper into the life I wanted.

Somewhere along the way I started to see life differently — not as a test to pass or a ladder to climb, but as a **game**. One you're far freer to play than you think. This book is how I play it: the principles I'd want my closest friend to know. Read it in an afternoon, then actually do the exercises — that's where it works. And know this going in: **you can do anything you genuinely commit to**. There's nothing special about me that isn't also in you.

PART ONE

The Game

Why you're freer than you were
ever told — and the lens that
changes everything.

PART I — THE GAME

01

Life is a game.

Start here, because it changes everything that follows: you are far freer than you were ever told. Life is less a test to pass than a game to play — so play it like one.

A game has a player, a world to explore, and the freedom to choose how you move through it. So do you. The difference is that most people never realize they're free to play at all — so they accept the rules they were handed and spend their lives chasing a scoreboard they never chose.

And here's the thought that either frees you or unsettles you: there's a real chance this **is** a kind of game — a simulation. Brilliant people take the possibility seriously now. But you don't need to believe it to use it. Whether this is a simulation, a dream, or one short and improbable life on a rock spinning through space, the conclusion is the same — and it's liberating.

If life is a game, the only way to lose is to spend it playing someone else's.

So here's the principle I live by: **only spend your life on what you genuinely want and believe in.** Not what your parents, teachers, feed, or some inherited program told you that you **should**. Those are someone else's dreams. You're allowed to set them down.

This isn't permission to be reckless — it's permission to be **deliberate**. The rest of this book is how you find what's truly

yours, and how to build a life around it.

PART I — THE GAME

02

**The lie you were
sold.**

Most people are playing a game designed by someone who never had their interests in mind.

The default path is seductive because it's **legible**: good grades, good degree, good job, climb, retire, then — finally — do what you actually wanted. The problem is the math. You trade your most alive decades for a permission slip to live that arrives, if it arrives at all, when your energy is mostly spent.

Worse, it optimizes for the wrong score. It teaches you to chase **money and status as the goal** — when both are meant to be byproducts, not destinations. It rewards **fitting in** over **finding out**. By the time most people look "successful," they've spent so long answering other people's questions that they've forgotten how to ask their own.

Signs you're playing someone else's game

- You can describe your job but not your **why**.
- Sunday nights feel heavier than they should.
- Your goals would impress your parents more than your younger self.
- You're chasing the next level but can't say what's at the top.

None of this means you're broken. It means you were handed the wrong objectives. The good news: in this game, you're allowed to put them down and write your own.

PART I — THE GAME

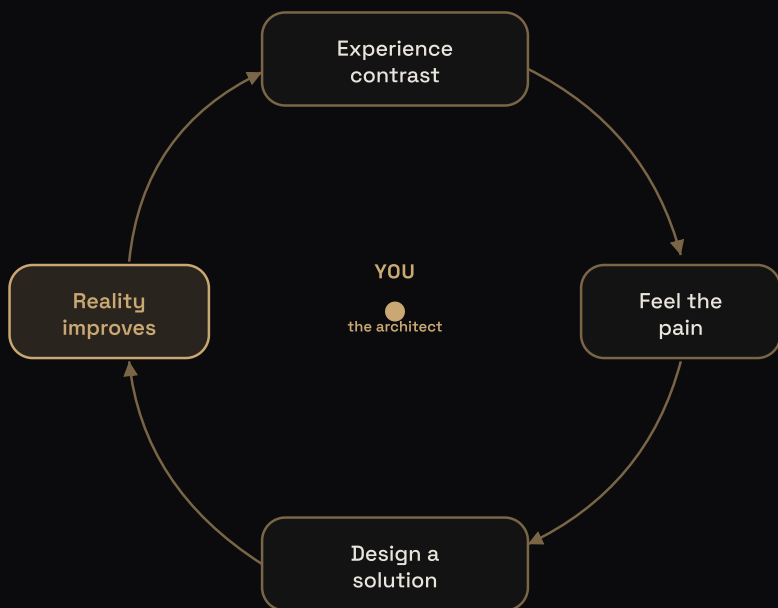
03

**You are an architect
of reality.**

Here's the idea that ties this entire book together. You are not a passenger in reality. You are one of its architects.

Every experience you've had — the good, and especially the painful — has shaped you into who you are. And it did something more: it handed you a private set of **pain points**. Things that frustrated you, broke your heart, made you think "this shouldn't be this way." Most people bury those. I think they're instructions.

Because the things that hurt you are the things you understand from the inside. They're the problems you're uniquely equipped to feel — and therefore to solve. I believe our job as humans is simple and profound: **experience contrast, then design and redesign reality to make it better — for ourselves and for everyone.**



THE ARCHITECT'S LOOP

This is why your story matters. The contrast you've lived — where you came from, what you lacked, what you longed for — is the raw material for what you're meant to build. You're not behind because of your past. You were being equipped by it.

Hold this lens as you read on. Purpose, integrity, the work — they all flow from here: **turn your pain into something that makes the world better.**

PART I — THE GAME

04

**We all start
somewhere.**

Nobody chooses their opening position. The country, the family, the body, the bank balance you were born into — none of it was your move.

That can feel unfair, and sometimes it is. But the only question that changes anything is the one you **can** answer: **what will you do with the position you were given?**

I started with no money, no degree, and no plan — just a free flight and a willingness to figure it out. Other people start with far more, or far less. It doesn't matter as much as you'd think. The game isn't won from the best starting square; it's won by the players who take their square seriously and keep moving.

So drop the comparison. Someone will always have started ahead of you, and someone will always have started behind. Your only real competition is who you were yesterday. That's the whole game — and it's a game you can always win.

EXERCISE · YOUR STARTING SQUARE

Own your position

Honestly, what position were you dealt — what you were given, and what you weren't?

Name one advantage hidden inside it that someone with a "better" start would never have.

PART TWO

Know Yourself

The inner game — purpose,
integrity, and becoming someone
you respect.

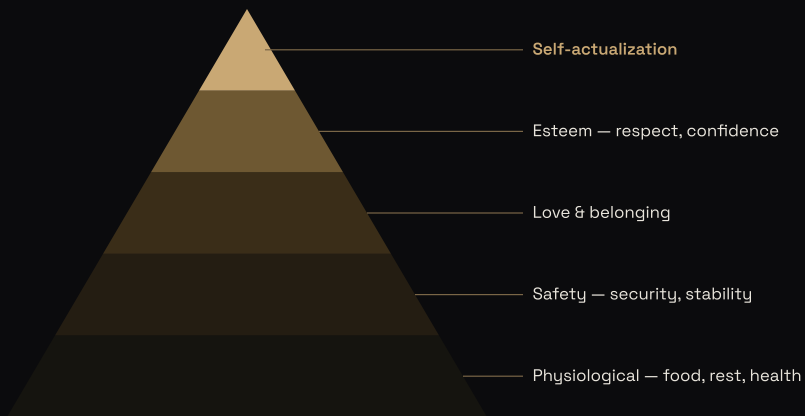
PART II — KNOW YOURSELF

05

Maslow & the climb.

Before you optimize your moves, understand what you're playing for. Abraham Maslow mapped it better than anyone.

His hierarchy says human needs stack. You secure the bottom before the top can pull at you: first survival, then safety, then love and belonging, then esteem — and finally, at the peak, **self-actualization**: becoming the fullest version of who you're capable of being.



MASLOW'S HIERARCHY OF NEEDS

This reframes your twenties. So much of that decade is really one project: **getting yourself into a position where self-actualization is even possible** — covering your basics, building a little security, freeing up enough energy to ask the bigger questions. That's not selling out. That's laying the foundation.

But never lose sight of why you're climbing. Modern life is engineered to trap you on the middle rungs, endlessly buying more safety and more status you don't need, so you never reach the top. The top is the whole point. Self-actualization is the real summit: a life where you're not just surviving or impressing anyone, but **becoming everything you're capable of being**.

PART II — KNOW YOURSELF

06

**Purpose is born
from pain.**

Here's where the architect's loop gets personal. I believe your purpose isn't invented — it's **excavated**. And the dig site is your own life.

Think about it. The people who build the best solutions to a problem are almost always people who lived the problem. The founder who struggled with their health builds the thing that would have saved them. The one who grew up without money builds the tool that gives others access. We solve, most powerfully, what we've personally felt.



HOW PAIN BECOMES PURPOSE

So your pain points aren't just wounds — they're **assignments**. The contrast you experienced throughout your life, as a kid and ever since, handed you a private map of what's broken and what should exist instead. Your purpose tends to live exactly where your deepest "this shouldn't be this way" meets your ability to do something about it.

This is also why two people can look at the same problem and only one feels called to fix it. The call comes from having **felt** it. Don't run from what hurt you. Study it. It's pointing somewhere.

EXERCISE • THE DIG

Mine your contrast

What have you struggled with, lacked, or longed for — as a kid and since?

For one of those: what would have helped you back then? Could you build or become that for someone else?

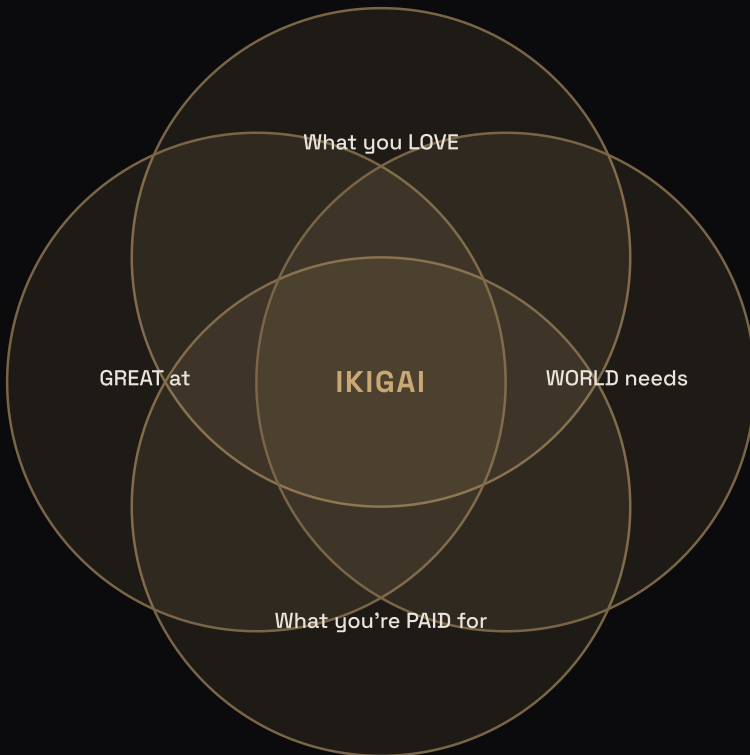
PART II — KNOW YOURSELF

07

**Ikigai: your reason
for being.**

Ikigai (ee-key-guy) is a Japanese idea meaning roughly "a reason for being" — the thing that makes getting up worth it. It's where your pain-born purpose becomes a life.

It's usually drawn as four overlapping circles. It became a cliché, which is a shame, because the model genuinely works the moment you stop staring at the diagram and start answering the four questions honestly.



THE FOUR CIRCLES OF IKIGAI

Your ikigai lives where all four overlap — and notice how "what the world needs" is exactly the pain you mined in the last chapter. You don't find the center by thinking. You find it by writing honest answers and watching for the word that keeps showing up.

EXERCISE • THE FOUR CIRCLES

One honest word per circle

What you **love** (what you'd do unpaid):

What you're **great at** (easy for you, hard for others):

What the **world needs** (the pain you've lived):

What you can be **paid** for:

EXERCISE • THE SYNTHESIS

Write your ikigai statement

"I exist to use my **[strength]** and my love of **[love]** to **[serve this need]** — built in a way that **[sustains me]**."

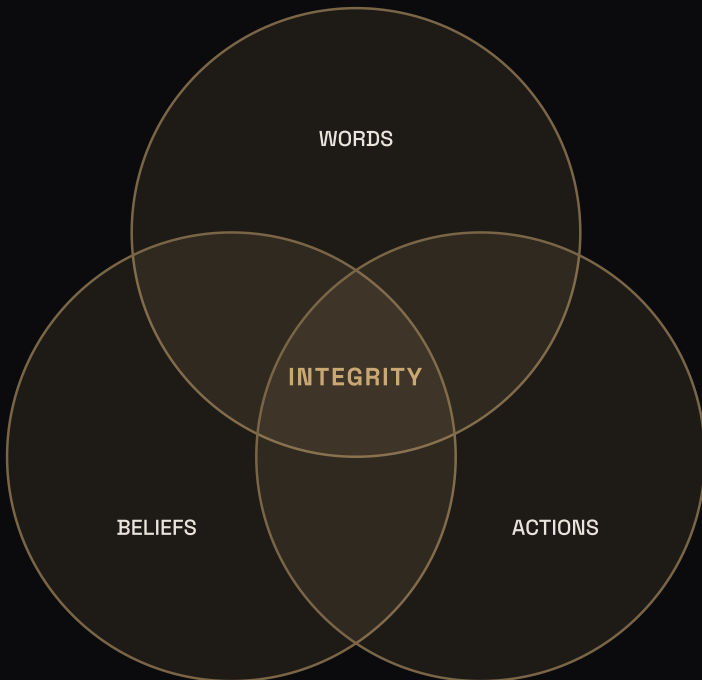
PART II — KNOW YOURSELF

08

Integrity: the inner foundation.

If there's one quality that quietly unlocks almost everything else, it's integrity. Not the moral-lecture kind — the structural kind.

Integrity means **alignment between your words, your beliefs, and your actions**. When all three point the same way, you're whole — "integrated," same root as the word. When they don't, you leak energy and trust, mostly with yourself.



WORDS · BELIEFS · ACTIONS IN ALIGNMENT

But I take it further than most. Integrity isn't only keeping your word to other people. It's **doing what you believe you're capable of** — because that belief is **yours**. Every time you know you could do something and don't, you break a promise to yourself. Enough of those, and you stop trusting your own word.

It also means living in line with what you now know: that you've experienced certain things, that you're capable of solving them, that you're meant to build. To know that and not act is its own kind of dishonesty. Integrity is closing the gap between who you know you are and how you actually live.

EXERCISE · THE PROMISE AUDIT

Find the leak

Where are your words, beliefs, and actions out of alignment right now?

One promise to yourself you'll keep this week — small enough you can't fail:

PART II — KNOW YOURSELF

09

The man in the glass.

There's an old poem I love — "The Man in the Glass," by Dale Wimbrow (1934). Its whole message is this: the only judge whose verdict truly matters is the one staring back at you in the mirror.

You can fool the whole world. You can collect the applause, the titles, the pats on the back. But you cannot fool the person in the glass — the one who knows exactly what you did when no one was watching. Their opinion of you is the one you have to live inside, every single day, right up to the end.

The most important relationship you'll ever have is with the person in the mirror.

This is why integrity isn't abstract — it's the daily practice of being able to **look at yourself**. When you act in alignment with your highest purpose, and you live the way you'd respect even with no audience, something quiet and powerful happens: you start to actually like the person in the glass.

And that approval — earned, not performed — is the foundation everything else is built on. You can't borrow it. You can't fake it. You build it one honest choice at a time, especially the ones only you will ever know about.

[A licensed copy of Dale Wimbrow's poem can be placed here.]

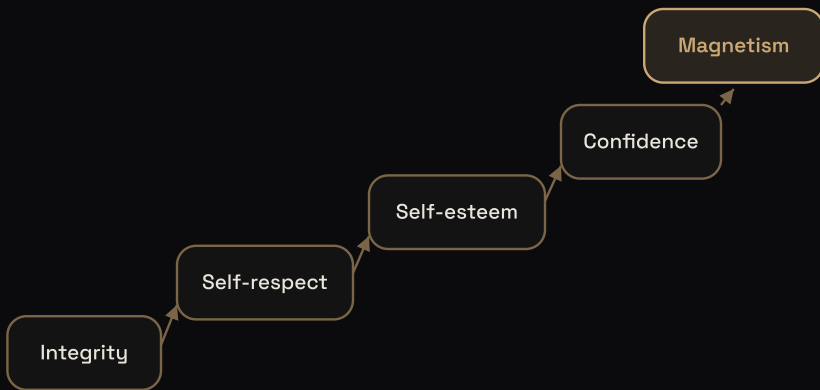
PART II — KNOW YOURSELF

10

Self-actualization & magnetism.

Here's where it all converges — and where it gets almost magical, even to me. When you live in your purpose and in integrity, you start to respect yourself. That respect compounds into something that changes your entire life.

The chain runs like this, and each link is earned by the one before it:



INTEGRITY → SELF-RESPECT → SELF-ESTEEM → CONFIDENCE →
MAGNETISM

When you've proven to yourself, over and over, that you do what you say and become what you're capable of, you start to genuinely **love who you are**. Not arrogance — a deep, quiet self-respect. That becomes self-esteem. And self-esteem, proven over time, becomes a level of confidence you cannot fake.

Here's the part most people miss: **that energy is magnetic.** When you're self-actualizing — working in your purpose, living in integrity, vibrating at your highest — people feel it. Friends feel it. Business partners feel it. And the right romantic partner feels it most of all. You stop chasing and start attracting, because you've become someone worth being drawn to.

I think of it like turning up the volume on who you really are. The louder and clearer you become, the easier it is for **your** people to find you — and the easier it becomes to filter out everyone who isn't. Self-actualization isn't selfish. It's the most generous signal you can send.

EXERCISE • TURN UP THE VOLUME

Where are you dimming yourself?

Where do you shrink, hide, or perform a smaller version of yourself to fit in?

What would change — in who you attract — if you let your full self be seen?

PART THREE

Live It

The outer game — the inputs,
choices, and traps that decide how
the life actually goes.

PART III — LIVE IT

11

**Inputs decide
outputs.**

You are not as self-made as you think. You are largely the sum of your inputs — and the great news is that most of them are yours to choose.



INPUTS RUN THROUGH YOU AND BECOME OUTPUTS

This is the most practical idea in the book. If you want better outputs — more energy, more clarity, better work, deeper fulfillment — you don't grind harder on the output. You upgrade the **inputs**.

The people you spend time with, the person you partner with, what you put in your body, your habits, the city you wake up in, what you let into your mind. These aren't background details. They're the dials. Willpower is overrated; a well-chosen environment does the heavy lifting for you. I moved to Bali for exactly this reason — not to escape, but to build the input that the rest of my life runs on.

EXERCISE • TUNE THE DIALS

One input, upgraded

Which single input — people, partner, body, habits, place, or media — is most quietly holding you back?

What's one change to it you could make this month?

PART III — LIVE IT

12

**Money is a
byproduct.**

Money is never the point — but it matters. See it for what it truly is: the byproduct of value you create, and a tool that lets you keep playing.

The reframe that changes everything: you don't chase money. You create something genuinely valuable for real people — ideally, a solution to a pain you understand — and money flows back as the natural echo of that. It isn't the prize. It's the receipt for value delivered, and fuel for the next build.

Get this right and money stops being a master you serve and becomes a tool you wield — to buy back your time, fund the mission, and build an abundant life with room for the people and experiences that matter. Aim at purpose and value. Let the abundance follow. It does, in ways that chasing it directly never produces.

I've been broke and I've been free, and the lesson held both times: the people who win this part aren't the ones who wanted money most. They're the ones who built something real and let the rest take care of itself.

EXERCISE · THE VALUE LEDGER

Follow the value, not the money

What real value do you create — or could you create — for other people?

If you doubled the value you give, what would happen to the money over time?

PART III — LIVE IT

13

**Travel: the fastest
way to grow.**

If you want to change how you think, change where you stand. Nothing rewired me faster than leaving.

Most of who you are isn't chosen — it's absorbed. The country you were born in, the people around you, the defaults of your culture: you mistake them for reality when they're just **one** version of it. Travel breaks the spell. You land somewhere new, watch people live full, happy lives by completely different rules, and a quiet realization sets in: **almost everything you thought was fixed is actually optional.**

That's the real gift — not the photos, the perspective. Eighty countries taught me that the "shoulds" I grew up with were local, not universal. Travel also forces growth on a schedule: every new place is a small test of resourcefulness, and you learn you can drop into the unknown with almost nothing and be fine. Carry that belief home and it changes what you'll attempt with everything else.

**You can't think your way out of a worldview
you've never stepped outside of.**

You don't need eighty countries. You need to leave your bubble often enough that you never confuse it for the whole world again.

EXERCISE • LEAVE THE BUBBLE

Disrupt your defaults

Where could you go — near or far — that would most challenge the way you currently see things?

When will you go? Put a real window on it.

PART III — LIVE IT

14

**Love: the richest
level.**

I'll be honest, because this book only works if I am: I haven't mastered this one. I'm single. I don't have kids yet. So take this as a map drawn by someone still walking toward the territory.

But the more I see, the more convinced I am that **love is the richest part of life, and the one most of us under-invest in.** It's easy to pour everything into the visible scoreboards — money, status, achievement — because they give clean feedback. Love is slower, messier, impossible to optimize the way I optimize everything else. Which is probably exactly why it's the deepest.

And it connects directly to everything in Part II. When you self-actualize — when you've become someone you genuinely respect — you stop chasing love and start attracting it. The most important person you'll ever choose is your partner, and that magnetic, self-respecting energy is what draws in someone extraordinary. Choose well: the right partner multiplies you; the wrong one can quietly cut you off at the knees. It's one of the highest-stakes decisions in the whole game.

You can win every other level and still feel poor if you skip this one.

So don't let the measurable crowd out the meaningful. Become someone worth loving by doing the inner work in

these pages — and stay open. The richest part of your life may be the part you haven't discovered yet. Mine probably is.

EXERCISE · WHAT YOU'RE BUILDING TOWARD

Name it

Describe the partnership you actually want — how it feels, not just what they look like.

Who would you have to become to attract and deserve that?

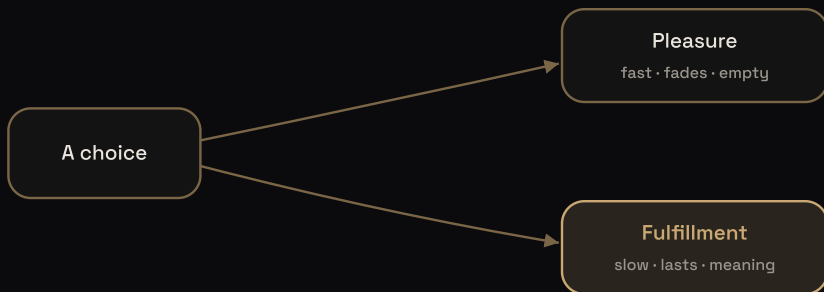
PART III — LIVE IT

15

**Fulfillment over
dopamine.**

There's a fork most people never notice they're standing at: the choice between **pleasure** and **fulfillment**. They are not the same, and chasing the first will quietly starve you of the second.

Pleasure is fast, cheap, and endless — the next hit of dopamine, the scroll, the drink, the easy high. It feels like living. But it leaves nothing behind. Fulfillment is slower and harder to earn — it's the feeling of going to sleep knowing you spent the day on something that mattered. One is a sugar rush. The other is nourishment.



THE FORK: PLEASURE OR FULFILLMENT

I'd rather chase the things that let me lie down at night genuinely fulfilled: **rich relationships, deep connection, impact-driven work, a body I've taken care of**. Hedonism is a trap precisely because it imitates the real thing while delivering the opposite. It doesn't just distract you — over time it cuts you off at the knees.

So be deliberate about what you chase, and ruthless about the traps. Watch the habits, what you put in your body, the easy dopamine loops. Protect your health like the asset it is. The fulfilled life isn't the one with the most pleasure — it's the one with the most meaning.

EXERCISE · PLEASURE VS. FULFILLMENT

Audit the loops

List your main daily dopamine sources. Mark each: cheap pleasure (P) or real fulfillment (F)?

One loop to cut, and one fulfilling thing to add in its place:

PART III — LIVE IT

16

Killing the shoulds.

Most people never hear their own answer because it's drowned out by everyone else's — and by programs running in the background they never chose to install.

You inherited a voice. Parents, teachers, culture, algorithms — all telling you what a good life is **supposed** to look like. Some of it is wisdom. A lot of it is someone else's fear wearing your name. Playing your own game means separating the two, ruthlessly.

EXERCISE • THE SHOULD AUDIT

Whose voice is that?

Write three things you feel you "should" do with your life.

For each — whose voice is it, really? And do you still agree?

Keep the shoulds that survive scrutiny. Delete the rest. The space they were taking up is exactly where your real life goes.

PART III — LIVE IT

17

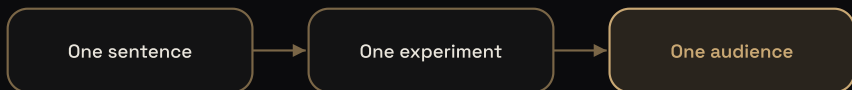
**From vision to
reality.**

Clarity is worthless until it touches the world. The bridge is a small, honest first step taken now.

The gap between people who "find themselves" and people who actually live it isn't talent or luck — it's the willingness to start before they feel ready, with whatever they have. My whole life is a stack of unqualified first steps: a van I'd never built, a company I'd never run, a country I'd never been to.

The 90-day bridge

- **One sentence:** the purpose you wrote earlier.
- **One experiment:** the smallest real thing you can ship in 90 days to test it.
- **One audience:** the people you'll do it for — by name if you can.



THE 90-DAY BRIDGE

EXERCISE · YOUR FIRST MOVE

Make it real

What could you ship in the next 90 days to prove (or disprove) your direction?

The very first action — the one you could take today:

PART III — LIVE IT

18

Enjoy the game.

Here's the one I almost forgot to write down, because it hides in plain sight: enjoy your life. Have fun. This — all of it — is supposed to be fun.

It sounds too simple, but ask the real question: why would you spend the one life you have doing things you don't enjoy? Not occasionally — as a whole. So many people build a life they're quietly miserable inside, grinding toward a finish line that, even when they cross it, doesn't feel like anything.

The nuance matters, because this isn't a license to chase comfort. The deepest fun on earth often comes wrapped in difficulty — the hard climb, the scary launch, the thing that stretches you. Doing hard things to solve a real problem or get where you're going is part of the joy, not the enemy of it. I'm not telling you to dodge difficulty or chase cheap pleasure — that was the last chapter.

I'm telling you something subtler: make sure that, underneath it all, **you're doing it because you love it**. That the game itself is one you'd actually choose to play. The hard parts should feel like the hard parts of a game you love — not a sentence you're serving.

If you're not enjoying the game, you're probably playing the wrong one. Change it.

Because underneath all of it — the purpose, the integrity, the building, the becoming — the whole point is to be glad you

were here. To have actually lived it, laughed through it, loved it. Don't get so serious about playing well that you forget the most important thing: you get to play at all.

EXERCISE • THE ENJOYMENT CHECK

Are you having fun?

What parts of your current life do you genuinely love and look forward to?

What are you merely tolerating — and could actually change?

PART III — LIVE IT

19

A life well lived.

Pull it all together and this is what you get — my honest definition of a life well played.

You take the position you were dealt and take it seriously. You mine your pain for purpose. You climb Maslow's ladder far enough to self-actualize, and you become the fullest version of yourself. You live in integrity, so you can look the person in the glass in the eye. That self-respect becomes confidence, and confidence becomes a magnetism that draws in the right people — friends, collaborators, and the partner you'll build a life with.

You treat money as fuel, not score. You choose your inputs — your people, your habits, your body, your place — like they determine your outputs, because they do. You chase fulfillment over cheap dopamine. You leave your bubble enough to keep growing. And you turn your experiences into something that makes reality a little better for everyone who comes after you.

That's it. That's the game. Not the most pleasure, not the most applause — the most **meaning**: rich relationships, impact-driven work, a healthy body, and the quiet wealth of becoming who you were capable of being.

| It's your game. Play it like it.

You can do this. You always could.

THE SHORT VERSION

**The principles, in
brief.**

Tear this page out. It's the whole book in one breath.

- **It's a game.** Play your own, never someone else's.
- **You're an architect.** Turn your contrast and pain into things that make reality better.
- **Start where you are.** Your only rival is who you were yesterday.
- **Climb Maslow.** Cover the basics so you can reach self-actualization.
- **Purpose hides in pain.** What hurt you points at what you're meant to build.
- **Find your ikigai.** Love × skill × need × value.
- **Live in integrity.** Align words, beliefs, actions — and do what you believe you can.
- **Befriend the person in the glass.** Their verdict is the only one that lasts.
- **Self-actualize.** It compounds into self-respect, confidence, and magnetism.
- **Choose your inputs.** People, partner, body, habits, place — they decide your outputs.
- **Money is a byproduct.** Create value; let abundance follow.
- **Chase fulfillment, not dopamine.** Meaning over cheap pleasure.
- **Love is the richest level.** Become magnetic; choose your partner well.

- **Start before you're ready.** Ship the first ugly step.

KEEP PLAYING

This was the map. Now go play.

If this cracked something open, don't let it close. A few ways to go deeper:

Find Your Purpose — the 10-part video course that takes this framework further.

1:1 Advisory & Ikigai Coaching — if you want me in the room while you do the work.

Everything lives at

shaidenvalentine.com

— SHADEN